

General Knowledge

Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Buddhism - I



BUDDHISM - I

History & Origin of Buddhism

- **Buddhism** arose approximately **2,600 years ago** in **India** as a spiritual path to overcome suffering and attain enlightenment.
- In **South and Southeast Asia**, **Buddhism** remains one of the most significant religions.
- **Siddhartha Gautama**, born in **563 BCE**, was the founder of **Buddhism**, also known as **Sakyamuni** or **Tathagata**.
- He was born into the **Sakya clan** of **Kapilvastu** (modern-day **Lumbini**, Nepal) to **King Siddhodana** and **Queen Mahamaya**.



The Early Life of Siddhartha Gautama

- **Siddhartha Gautama** lived a luxurious life as a prince, but he was deeply disturbed by the suffering he witnessed: **A corpse, An old man, A sick man, and A world renouncer**.
- At the age of **29**, he renounced his royal life and adopted the path of **asceticism** (extreme self-discipline).

- He spent **six years** practicing severe austerities, seeking the **truth** about suffering and its causes.



Enlightenment

- After renouncing severe asceticism, he meditated under a **pipal tree** (later known as the **Bodhi tree**) in **Bodhgaya, Bihar**.
- After **49 days of meditation**, Siddhartha attained **Bodhi** (enlightenment) and became the **Buddha** (the Enlightened One).
- The **pipal tree** became known as the **Bodhi Tree**, a symbol of **Buddhist enlightenment**.

The First Sermon: Turning the Wheel of Law (Dharma-Chakra-Pravartana)

- **Buddha** delivered his first sermon at **Sarnath, near Varanasi**, marking the **turning of the wheel of law**. This event is called **Dharma-Chakra-Pravartana**.
- In this sermon, he introduced the **Four Noble Truths** and the **Eightfold Path** to his disciples, forming the foundation of **Buddhist philosophy**.



Mahaparinirvana

- Buddha passed away at the age of **80** in **483 BCE** in **Kushinagar**, Uttar Pradesh. His death is known as **Mahaparinirvana**, signifying his final release from the cycle of rebirth.



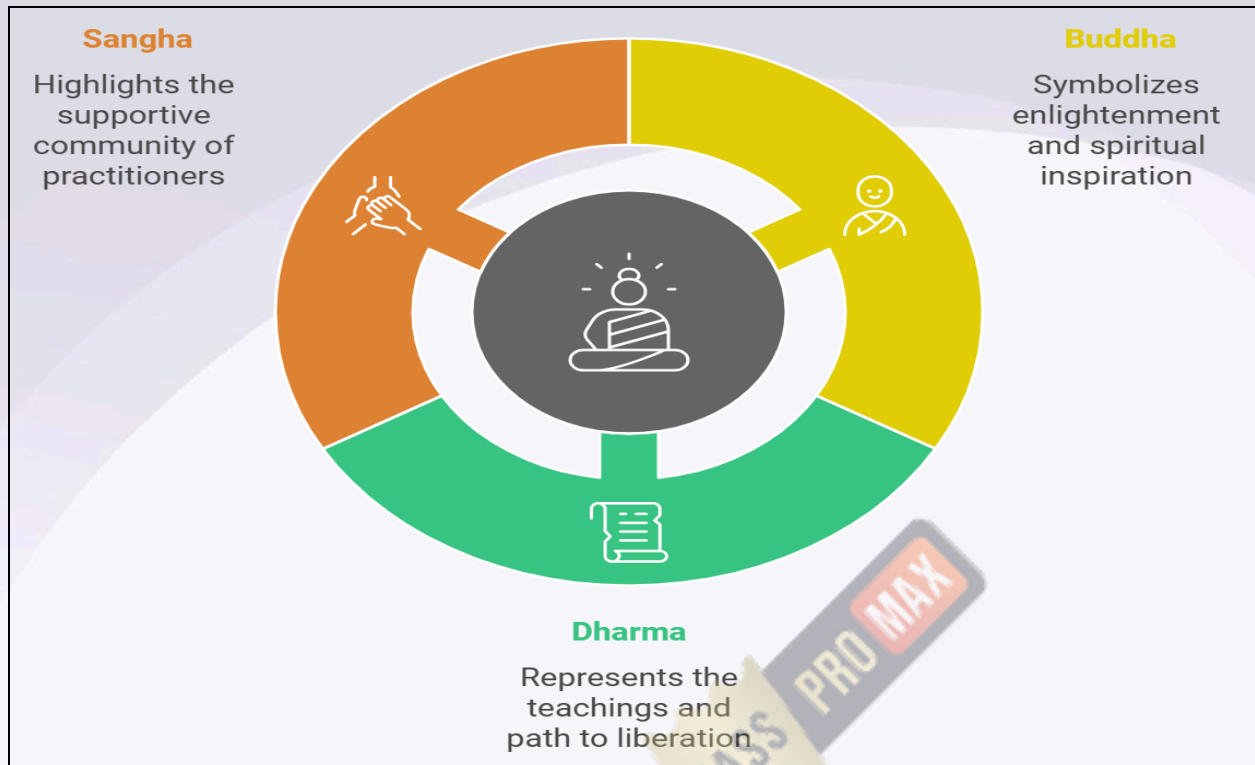
Causes for the Rise of Buddhism

- **Socio-Political Conditions:** During the **6th century BCE**, people were frustrated by **Brahmanical rituals, superstitions, and complexities of Vedic religion**.
- **Simple Doctrines:** Unlike the **Vedic religion**, Buddhism offered simple teachings like the **Four Noble Truths** and the **Eightfold Path** which were easy for the common people to follow.
- **Language of the People:** **Buddha** taught in **Prakrit**, the language of the masses, unlike the **Vedic Sanskrit**, which was restricted to the **Brahmins**.
- **The personality of Buddha:** His compassionate and kind **demeanour**, combined with his selfless actions, endeared him to the people.
- **Absence of Caste Discrimination:** Buddhism opposed the **caste system**, and people of all castes were allowed to join the **Sangha** (Buddhist monastic order).

Three Jewels of Buddhism

The "Three Jewels" or "Three Refuges" are central to Buddhist practice and belief. They represent the core values and guide practitioners on the path to enlightenment.

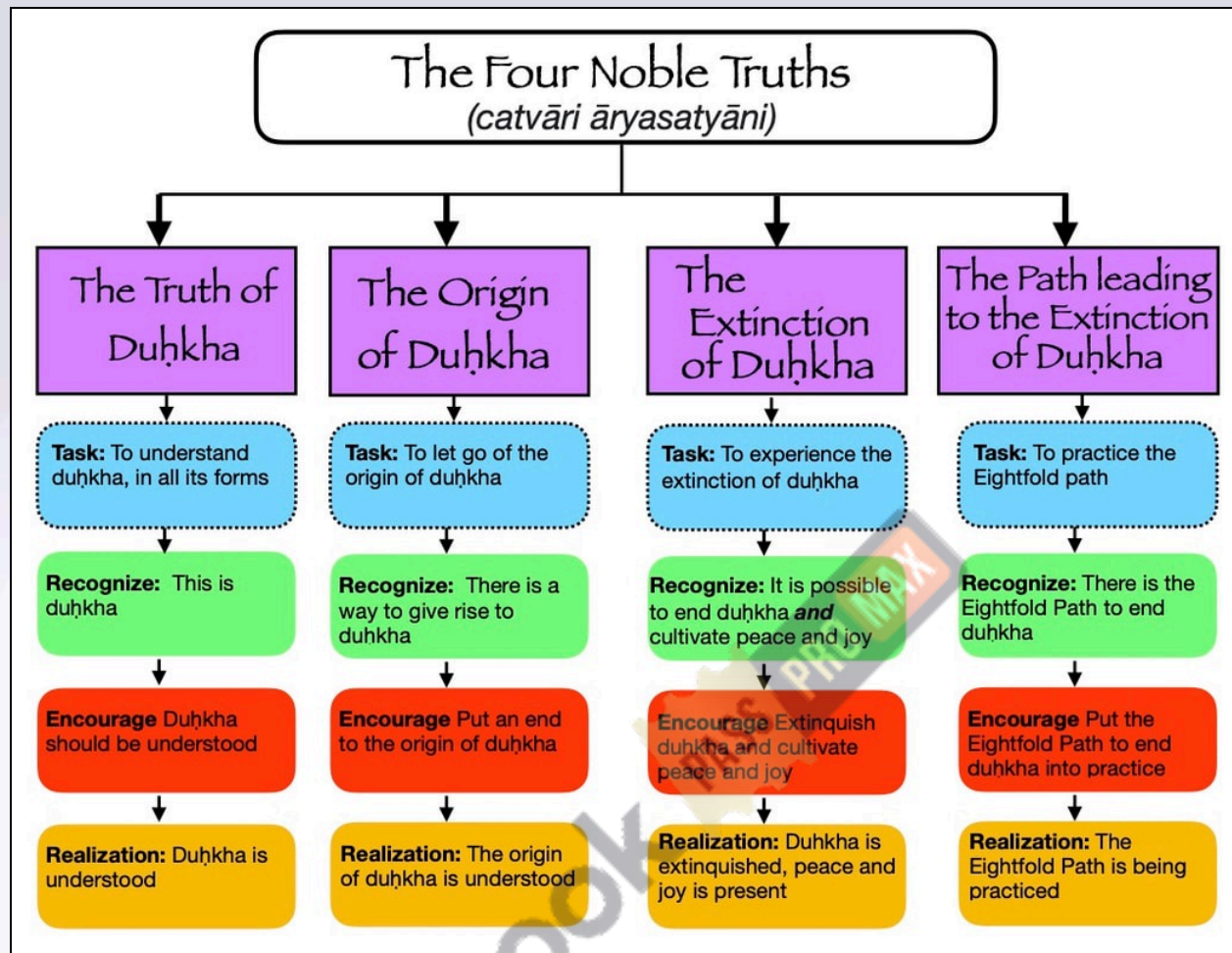
- **Buddha:** The **first jewel** is Buddha, who symbolizes the ideal of **enlightenment**. Buddha represents the **spiritual teacher** and **example** of what it means to be free from suffering and ignorance. Practitioners **take refuge** in the Buddha as an **inspiration** to seek their inner potential for enlightenment.
- **Dharma:** The **second jewel** is Dharma, the **teachings** of Buddha. Dharma serves as the **path** to enlightenment, offering **guidance** on living an ethical, mindful life. Dharma is considered the **truth** and encompasses **practices, moral codes, and wisdom** that help individuals achieve liberation.
- **Sangha:** The **third jewel** is Sangha, the **community** of practitioners. Sangha includes **monks, nuns, and lay followers** who support one another on the spiritual path. It emphasizes the importance of **community** in achieving and maintaining progress on the **path of enlightenment**.



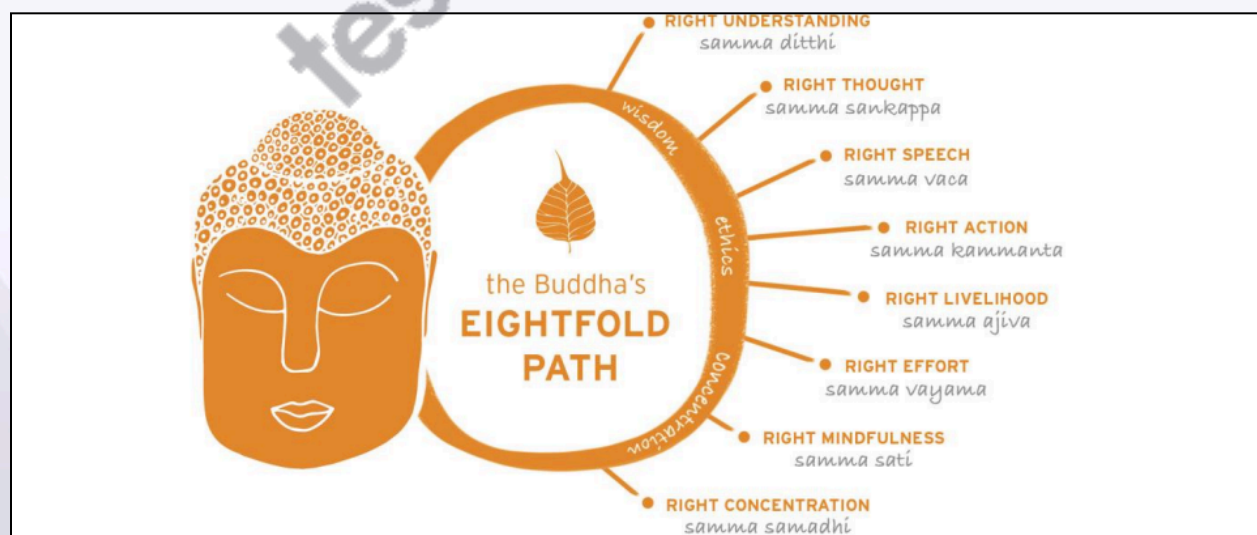
The Four Noble Truths (Ariya-Sacchani)

The **Four Noble Truths** form the essence of **Buddha's teachings**:

Noble Truth	Explanation
Dukkha (Truth of Suffering)	Life is full of suffering (Sabbam Dukham). Suffering exists in every aspect of life.
Samudaya (Cause of Suffering)	The cause of suffering is Trishna (desire or craving), which leads to attachment and unhappiness.
Nirodha (End of Suffering)	Suffering can end by attaining Nirvana or Nibbana , the cessation of all desires and attachments.
Ashtangika-Marga (Path to End Suffering)	The Eightfold Path offers a practical guide to end suffering and achieve enlightenment.



The Eightfold Path (Ashtangika Marga)



The **Eightfold Path** consists of eight interconnected practices that lead to spiritual awakening and liberation from suffering:

Step	Explanation
Right Vision (Samma Ditthi)	Understanding the true nature of reality and the path to transformation.
Right Thought (Samma Sankappa)	Developing thoughts of non-harm, compassion, and love towards others.
Right Speech (Samma Vacca)	Speaking truthfully and kindly, avoiding harmful or malicious words.
Right Action (Samma Kammanta)	Acting ethically, refraining from violence, stealing, and immoral behavior .
Right Livelihood (Samma Ajiva)	Earning a living in a way that does not harm others or exploit them.
Right Effort (Samma Vayama)	Making a conscious effort to develop positive habits and eliminate negative tendencies.
Right Mindfulness (Samma Sati)	Practising awareness of body, mind, and feelings, staying present in every moment.
Right Concentration (Samma Samadhi)	Achieving deep meditative concentration to purify the mind and attain liberation.

Buddhist Councils (Sangitis)

The **Buddhist Councils** played a vital role in preserving and spreading the teachings of **Buddha**. These councils were convened to address doctrinal differences, maintain the purity of Buddha's teachings, and establish authoritative texts.

Council	Date	Location	Presided By	Patron	Key Outcome
First Buddhist Council	483 BCE	Rajgriha	Mahakassapa	Ajatashatru	Compilation of Vinaya and Sutta Pitaka to preserve Buddha's teachings.
Second Buddhist Council	383 BCE	Vaishali	Sabakami	Kalashoka	Addressed corruption in the Sangha, and reaffirmed monastic discipline.
Third Buddhist Council	250 BCE	Pataliputra	Moggaliputta Tissa	Ashoka	Theravada Buddhism was established; Abhidhamma Pitaka was compiled; missionaries were sent to spread Buddhism abroad.
Fourth Buddhist Council	1st century CE	Kashmir	Vasumitra (under the patronage of Kanishka)	Kanishka	Division of Buddhism into Mahayana and Hinayana sects; Sanskrit became the language of Buddhist scriptures.

Doctrines of Buddhism

- **Don't covet the property of others:**
 - This doctrine emphasises **ethical behaviour** by encouraging people to avoid desires or cravings for others' possessions.
 - The focus is on detachment from material wealth, promoting a sense of contentment and moral living.
- **Don't commit violence:**

- One of the foundational principles of **Buddhism** is **Ahimsa** (non-violence). It prohibits harming any living being, be it human or animal.
- This extends to physical violence, mental harm, and verbal abuse. This doctrine promotes peace, compassion, and kindness toward all forms of life.
- **Don't use intoxicants:**
 - **Buddhism** discourages the consumption of any intoxicants (like alcohol or drugs) that cloud the mind and hinder a person's ability to be mindful and aware.
 - The purpose is to promote **clear thinking**, **self-control**, and a focused path toward enlightenment.
- **Don't speak a lie:**
 - Truthfulness is a core Buddhist value. Speaking the truth builds trust and reduces harm in relationships.
 - **Falsehoods** lead to confusion, misunderstanding, and suffering.
- **Don't indulge in corrupt practices:**
 - This doctrine is aimed at maintaining **ethical integrity** in all aspects of life.
 - It discourages cheating, dishonesty, bribery, and any form of **unethical conduct** that could harm society or individual moral growth.

Beliefs in Buddhism

- **Emphasis on Ahimsa (Non-Violence):**
 - **Buddhism** upholds **Ahimsa** as a central tenet.
 - The belief is that no harm should be done to any living creature, and this non-violent approach extends to thoughts, words, and actions.
- **Vegetarianism:**
 - Although not a strict requirement, many **Buddhists** adopt a **vegetarian diet** as a reflection of their commitment to **non-violence** and compassion toward animals.
- **No Recognition of God or Soul:**
 - **Buddhism** rejects the existence of a **creator god** and denies the concept of a permanent **soul** (Atman).
 - Instead, it teaches that existence is marked by **impermanence** and that enlightenment is achieved by realizing the non-self (Anatman).
- **Criticism of the Varna System:**
 - **Buddha** strongly opposed the **varna (caste) system**, particularly the notion of social hierarchy based on birth.

- He believed in equality and advocated for the upliftment of **Shudras** (lowest caste) and **women**, ensuring they could join the **Sangha** (monastic community) on equal terms.
- **Overcoming Hatred with Love:**
 - **Buddha** taught that evil should be countered with **goodness** and **hatred** with **love**. He believed that kindness and compassion were the means to overcome negativity and violence.
- **Buddhism and Varna System:**
 - **Buddhism** did not entirely reject the **varna system**, but it redefined its meaning.
 - It placed emphasis on **actions** (Karma) and **attributes** rather than **birth**, suggesting that one's position in society is determined by moral conduct, not caste.

The Eight Great Bodhisattvas

- **Bodhisattvas** are revered figures in **Mahayana Buddhism**. They are enlightened beings who have chosen to remain in the cycle of **samsara** to help others attain enlightenment.
- Each of the eight **Bodhisattvas** represents specific **virtues** such as **wisdom**, **compassion**, and **power**, playing a pivotal role in guiding devotees toward **spiritual liberation**.
- For example, **Avalokiteshvara**, known for his compassion, is widely worshipped across Buddhist cultures, symbolizing mercy and kindness.

Bodhisattva	Description
Manjushri	Manjushri is the embodiment of wisdom . He is depicted with a blazing sword in his right hand, symbolizing the wisdom that cuts through ignorance and delusion . He is one of the most revered Bodhisattvas in Buddhism.

Avalokiteshvara (Padmapani/Lokeshvara)	Avalokiteshvara symbolizes infinite compassion . He is associated with the Buddha Amitabha and is believed to be an incarnation of compassion . He is usually depicted holding a lotus flower and is known for his ability to relieve suffering.
Vajrapani	Vajrapani represents the power and energy of all Buddhas. He is often depicted in a warrior stance encircled by flames, symbolizing his ability to remove obstacles and transform negativity into enlightenment.
Kshitigarbha	Kshitigarbha is famous for his vow to save all beings , including those suffering in hell and children who died young. He plays a vital role in the afterlife , offering salvation to souls between Buddha's death and the arrival of Maitreya.
Akashagarbha	Akashagarbha is revered for his ability to cleanse sins and offer wisdom . He is depicted in a serene pose, often holding a sword to cut through negative emotions, symbolizing his power to eliminate impurities.
Samantabhadra	Samantabhadra is known for his ten vows that encompass ethical conduct and altruism . He is often depicted as part of the Shakyamuni Trinity along with Gautama Buddha and Manjushri .

Sarvanivarana-Vishkambhin	Sarvanivarana-Vishkambhin represents the purification of internal and external obstacles on the path to enlightenment. He purifies the hindrances that people face in their spiritual journeys.
Maitreya	Maitreya is regarded as the future Buddha , destined to return and restore true Buddhist teachings after the decline of the current era. He is expected to bring salvation and establish peace in the future.

Mudras in Buddhism

S. No	Mudra	Description	Image
1	Dharmachakra Mudra	Dharmachakra means 'Wheel of Dharma' in Sanskrit. Vairochana, the first Dhyanī Buddha, demonstrates this mudra.	

2	Bhumis parsha Mudra	The word 'bhumisparsha' means 'touching the soil.' The 'earth witness' is another name for it. This mudra depicts Akshobhya, the second Dhyani Buddha.	
3	Varada Mudra	This mudra represents kindness, compassion, and blessings. It's the mudra for realising one's desire to devote oneself to human salvation. This mudra is shown by Ratnasambhava, the third Dhyani Buddha.	
4	Dhyana Mudra	With one or both hands, make the Dhyana mudra. Amitabha, also known as Amitayus, the fourth Dhyani Buddha, demonstrates this mudra.	

5	Abhaya Mudra	In Sanskrit, the word 'abhaya' denotes fearlessness. As a result, this mudra represents safety, tranquility, and the removal of fear. Amoghasiddhi, the sixth Dhyani Buddha, depicts the Abhaya mudra.	
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Spread of Buddhism

- **Buddhism** spread rapidly across **North India** during Buddha's lifetime and beyond, thanks to the missionary activities of the **Sangha**.
- **Emperor Ashoka** played a pivotal role in the global expansion of **Buddhism**. After the **Kalinga War**, he embraced **Buddhism** and sent missionaries to places like **Sri Lanka, Greece, Myanmar, Thailand, and Central Asia**.
- **Ashoka's Edicts**: These inscriptions spread across India and beyond, promoted **Buddha's teachings** and outlined the **Dhamma** (moral code).

Impact of Buddhism

- **Ahimsa (Non-violence)**: **Buddhism** promoted **non-violence** as a core ethical principle, influencing **Indian culture** and later leaders like **Mahatma Gandhi**.
- **Art and Architecture**: Magnificent architectural structures like **stupas** (e.g., **Sanchi, Bharhut**), **rock-cut caves** (e.g., **Ajanta, Ellora**), and **Buddhist sculptures** bear testimony to the impact of **Buddhism** on art.
- **Education**: **Buddhist Universities** such as **Nalanda, Taxila, and Vikramsila** became major centres of learning, attracting scholars from around the world.
- **Language Development**: The **Pali** and **Prakrit** languages flourished due to the teachings of **Buddha** and Buddhist scriptures.

Decline of Buddhism

- The **corruption** of the **Sangha**, the rise of **ritualistic practices**, and the **fragmentation** of Buddhism into **Hinayana**, **Mahayana**, **Vajrayana**, and **Tantrayana** sects contributed to its decline.
- **Muslim invasions** in the **12th century CE** and the rise of **Brahmanical Hinduism** led to the destruction of **Buddhist monasteries** and a decline in **Buddhism** in India.
- **Survival in Asia**: Despite its decline in India, **Buddhism** flourished in **East Asia** (China, Japan) and **Southeast Asia** (Thailand, Myanmar, Sri Lanka).



Gave the concept of
KARMA & REBIRTH
The relationship of
Cause  *Effect*

WHO IS BUDDHA?
Siddhārtha Gautam
📍 Lumbini, Nepal


TEACHINGS
Life is *Suffering*
Suffering is caused by
Desire & Attachment
Suffering can be
Eliminated

NIRVANA
Meditated under
the Bodhi Tree in
BODH GAYA,
for **7 WEEKS**
until he attained
Enlightenment

AUSPICIOUS SYMBOLS OF BUDDHISM



PARASOL
(Chatra):
Royalty & Protection



GOLD FISHES
(Suvamamatsya):
Good Fortune, Fertility & Salvation



TREASURE VASE
(kalasha):
Spiritual & Material Abundance



LOTUS
(Padma):
Mental & Spiritual Purity



CONCH SHELL
(Sankha):
Spread of His Teachings



ENDLESS KNOT
(Shrivatsa):
Infinite Wisdom



VICTORY BANNER
(Dhvaja):
Wisdom over Ignorance



WHEEL
(Dharmachakra):
Teachings of Buddha